

Thursday, 13 August 2026.

Your daily radio show prep — three top news stories, forward-looking showbiz, sport that matters this week, talkback prompts, and day notes for today and tomorrow. Built fresh every weekday, ready by 3pm for tomorrow's show.

00 — WEATHER

Tomorrow's forecast

LONDON

Clear

37° 21°

BIRMINGHAM

Overcast

36° 20°

MANCHESTER

Overcast

35° 22°

GLASGOW

Light drizzle

24° 18°

01 — NEWS

Today's top stories

- 1 A double killer and rapist from Tottenham has been given a whole life sentence and will spend the rest of his life in prison.**

Simon Levy was sentenced for the murder of two women and the rape of a third. This means he will never be released from jail.

CRIME · UK

- 2 The government is set to hold a Cobra meeting today to discuss the extreme heat, as temperatures across the UK surge once again.**

This summer has already seen a record-breaking number of days above 30 degrees Celsius. The meeting will address the ongoing challenges of the heatwave.

WEATHER · UK

- 3 The ongoing conflict in the Middle East could hit UK economic growth next year, according to a warning from the government.**

The situation has already pushed up oil and fuel prices, causing disruption to global supply chains. This could have a significant impact on the UK economy.

ECONOMY · UK

- 4 The early release scheme for prisoners is risking more serious crimes, according to the chief inspector of probation.**

The probation service in England and Wales is already under 'unprecedented pressure'. The inspector warns that releasing prisoners early could exacerbate the problem.

JUSTICE · UK

- 5 Serious failings have been found in a new military crimes unit, according to a leaked internal report.**

The report raises concerns about the unit responsible for investigating the most serious crimes within the armed forces. This could have significant implications for military justice.

MILITARY · UK

What's coming up

1 **The final celebrity for this year's Strictly Come Dancing has been announced, and it's a familiar face from Gavin & Stacey!**

Melanie Walters, who played Gwen in the much-loved BBC sitcom, will be hitting the dancefloor. She's the 15th and final star to join the line-up.

ON AIR – Are you excited to see Melanie Walters on Strictly? Who do you think will be her dance partner?

TV · COMING UP

2 **Nicholas Hoult is the latest big name to join the cast of the new Harry Potter TV series, taking on a magical role!**

The actor, known for 'X-Men' and 'Mad Max', will play the flamboyant Gilderoy Lockhart. He joins an already impressive cast for the highly anticipated show.

ON AIR – Nicholas Hoult as Gilderoy Lockhart – what do you make of that casting? Who else would you like to see join?

TV · COMING UP

3 **Calling all wizards and witches! The UK's largest Harry Potter shop is set to open its doors in London later this year.**

Warner Bros has announced the flagship store will be inspired by the magical Diagon Alley. It's set to open on November 4th.

ON AIR – Are you excited for the new Harry Potter shop? What's the first thing you'll be looking for?

RETAIL · COMING UP

4 **Spotify is introducing a new feature to help listeners identify AI-generated artists and will remove them from recommendations.**

From mid-September, a new label will tell you if an artist is artificial intelligence. This comes as AI music becomes more prevalent.

ON AIR – What do you think of Spotify's move to label AI-generated music? Will it change how you listen?

MUSIC · COMING UP

5 **The boy who shot to fame with the 'Baby Shark' song is all grown up and ready to make his K-pop debut!**

Now 17, the star from the most-watched YouTube video of all time is pursuing a career in K-pop. It's quite a change from his childhood hit!

ON AIR – From Baby Shark to K-pop star – what a journey! Do you think he'll be a big success?

MUSIC · COMING UP

On the schedule

1 **Manchester United's new signing Youri Tielemans says he owes Aston Villa the world, but joining United is a dream come true.**

The midfielder, who joined from Villa for £35m, said it was 'third time lucky' for him to finally make the move. He's given his first extended interview since signing.

ON AIR – Tielemans is a big signing for Man Utd. Do you think he'll be a game-changer for them this season?
FOOTBALL · UK

2 **England rugby coach Steve Borthwick has shaken up his squad, handing out first-time central contracts to five players.**

Asher Opoku-Fordjour, Alex Coles, Guy Pepper, Jack van Poortvliet and Seb Atkinson are the new faces. It's a clear signal of Borthwick's plans for the future.

ON AIR – A big shake-up for England rugby! Who are you most excited to see make their mark?
RUGBY · UK

3 **England's new Test cricket captain Joe Root has abolished the midnight curfew previously imposed on the team.**

The curfew was a rule under his predecessor Ben Stokes. Root's decision suggests a fresh approach to team management and player freedom.

ON AIR – Root's scrapping the curfew – good move for team morale, or a risky decision?
CRICKET · UK

4 **Great Britain's Max Burgin and Ben Pattison have both qualified for the men's 800m final at the European Athletics Championships.**

Both athletes finished first and second in their respective semi-final races. They'll be hoping for medals in the final.

ON AIR – Two Brits in the 800m final! How do you fancy their chances for a medal?
ATHLETICS · UK

5 **Great Britain has secured a stunning one-two in the men's 100m final at the European Athletics Championships!**

Romell Glave took the gold medal, with fellow Brit Jeremiah Azu finishing in second place. It's a fantastic result for British sprinting.

ON AIR – A gold and silver for Great Britain in the 100m! What a performance – did you watch it?
ATHLETICS · UK

Quick hits

- 1 A new appreciation for 'the art of looking out of the window' is gaining popularity, especially during quiet moments.**
Many are rediscovering the simple joy of observing the world go by, finding it a mindful and peaceful pastime that offers a break from screens. It's a delightful way to reconnect with your surroundings, even from indoors.
- 2 The surprising trend of 'collecting unique old teacups' is charming tea enthusiasts across the country.**
From intricate floral patterns to quirky animal designs, people are enjoying the hunt for distinctive teacups at antique shops and markets. It's becoming a delightful way to add character to their daily brew.
- 3 Experts suggest that 'the simple act of watering houseplants' can significantly boost your mood.**
Connecting with nature, even on a small scale, provides a sense of purpose and calm. The routine of nurturing something green can be surprisingly therapeutic and rewarding.
- 4 The delightful resurgence of 'homemade lemonade stands' is bringing a taste of nostalgia to local communities.**
Children and adults alike are setting up charming stands, offering refreshing drinks and a friendly wave. It's a lovely way to connect with neighbours and enjoy a classic summer treat.
- 5 A new study indicates that 'the scent of freshly baked bread' can evoke strong feelings of comfort and happiness for many.**
The warm, inviting aroma is often linked to cherished memories of home and family, proving that some sensory experiences truly are universal mood-lifters. Perhaps it's time to get baking!
- 6 Gardeners are discovering the joy of 'growing giant vegetables' in their back gardens.**
From enormous marrows to colossal cabbages, the challenge of cultivating impressively sized produce is proving a fun and rewarding endeavour. It certainly makes for a conversation starter over the garden fence!
- 7 The charming trend of 'leaving painted pebbles in public places' for others to find is spreading cheer.**
People are decorating small stones with colourful designs and uplifting messages, hiding them in parks and along pathways for strangers to discover. It's a lovely, simple way to share a moment of unexpected joy.

05 – TALKBACK

For the phone lines

OUR SURVEY SAID

Q Our survey said that over 70% of us admit to secretly 'doing' what when we're trying to quickly judge the temperature of a drink, even though we know it's probably not the most accurate method?

ANSWER: POKING IT WITH A FINGER, USUALLY THE PINKY!

Q Our survey said that over 65% of us admit to having a particular 'odd habit' they absolutely have to do before enjoying a lovely, fresh banana. What is it?

ANSWER: SNIFFING THE VERY END TO CHECK IT'S PERFECTLY RIPE!

TALK TOPIC

- You know how sometimes you discover a 'quirky little shop' in a town you're visiting, and it just becomes the highlight of your day?

What's the most unusual or charming independent shop you've ever stumbled upon, and what made it so memorable?

- We all have those 'favourite public benches' in our local area, don't we, that just seem to offer the perfect spot for a moment of quiet reflection or people-watching?

Where is your go-to bench, and what makes it such a special place for you?

TRUE STORY OR JACKANORY – LISTENERS GUESS

FACT **History.** During World War II, carrots were promoted by the British government as a way to help people see in the dark, to encourage consumption and to disguise the real reason for improved night vision: new radar technology.

FICTION **Made up, but believable.** The first ever recorded traffic light system was invented in ancient Rome to manage chariot congestion at busy crossroads.

06 – LOTTERY

Jackpots ahead

NEXT EUROMILLIONS JACKPOT

£24 million

Next Tuesday or Friday · estimated

NEXT NATIONAL LOTTERY JACKPOT

£24 million

Next Wednesday or Saturday · estimated

07 – FACTS OF THE DAY

Did you know?

- The 'richest' soil on Earth can be found in the Black Sea region, known for its fertile 'chernozem' soil.
- A group of ferrets is collectively known as a 'business'.
- The British Isles are home to over 10,000 miles of coastline, offering a vast array of landscapes.
- The world's oldest known piece of chewing gum is over 9,000 years old, found in Finland.
- Butterflies taste with their feet, using chemoreceptors to find host plants and nectar.
- The largest active volcano in Europe is Mount Etna, located on the island of Sicily, Italy.
- The national animal of Scotland is the unicorn, a mythical creature symbolising purity and innocence.
- The 'penny-farthing' bicycle was so named because the two wheels, one large and one small, resembled the British coins.

On this day

Day 225 of the year, 140 days left in 2026. Today Christian feast day: Benedetto Sinigardi; Christian feast day: Benildus Romançon; Christian feast day: Cassian of Imola; Christian feast day: Clara Maass (Lutheran Church). Star sign Leo, birthstone Peridot.

TODAY'S BIRTHDAYS

- 1982 — Sebastian Stan, Romanian-American actor
- 1961 — Neil Mallender, English cricketer and umpire
- 1951 — Dan Fogelberg, American singer-songwriter and guitarist (died 2007)
- 1974 — Joe Perry, English snooker player
- 1964 — Debi Mazar, American actress
- 1967 — Quinn Cummings, American actress, author, and entrepreneur
- 1944 — Kevin Tighe, American actor
- 1945 — Robin Jackman, Indian-English cricketer and sportscaster (died 2020)

THE DAY TODAY

- 1964 — Peter Allen and Gwynne Evans are hanged for the murder of John Alan West becoming the last people executed in the United Kingdom.
- 1940 — World War II: The German Luftwaffe launches an air operation, codenamed Adlertag, during the Battle of Britain in an attempt to destroy the British Royal Air Force.
- 1944 — World War II: German troops begin the pillage and razing of Anogeia in Crete that would continue until September 5.

TODAY IN MUSIC

- 1918 — Women enlist in the United States Marine Corps for the first time. Opha May Johnson is the first woman to enlist.
- 1920 — Polish–Soviet War: The Battle of Warsaw begins and will last till August 25. The Red Army is defeated.

TODAY IN HISTORY

- 1913 — First production in the UK of stainless steel by Harry Brearley.

1968 — Alexandros Panagoulis attempts to assassinate the Greek dictator Colonel Georgios Papadopoulos in Varkiza, Athens.

- 1942 — Major General Eugene Reybold of the U.S. Army Corps of Engineers authorizes the construction of facilities that would house the "Development of Substitute Materials" project, better known as the Manhattan Project.

A peek at tomorrow

Day 226 of the year, 139 days left in 2026. Today Christian feast day: Arnold of Soissons; Christian feast day: Domingo Ibáñez de Erquicia; Christian feast day: Eusebius of Rome; Christian feast day: Fachtna of Rosscarbery. Star sign Leo, birthstone Peridot.

TOMORROW'S BIRTHDAYS

- 1946 — Susan Saint James, American actress
- 1968 — Catherine Bell, English-American actress and producer
- 1959 — Marcia Gay Harden, American actress
- 1956 — Andy King, English footballer and manager (died 2015)
- 1965 — Paul Broadhurst, English golfer
- 1946 — Larry Graham, American soul/funk bass player and singer-songwriter
- 1983 — Elena Baltacha, Ukrainian-Scottish tennis player (died 2014)
- 1983 — Mila Kunis, Ukrainian-American actress

THE DAY TOMORROW

- 1947 — Pakistan gains independence from the British Empire as the Dominion of Pakistan, due to the partition of India.
- 2006 — Lebanon War: A ceasefire takes effect three days after the United Nations Security Council's approval of United Nations Security Council Resolution 1701, formally ending hostilities between Lebanon and Israel.
- 2015 — The U.S. Embassy in Havana, Cuba re-opens after 54 years of being closed when Cuba–United States relations were broken off.

TOMORROW IN MUSIC

- 1967 — UK Marine Broadcasting Offences Act 1967 declares participation in offshore pirate radio illegal.
- 1947 — Pakistan gains independence from the British Empire as the Dominion of Pakistan, due to the partition of India.

Coming to cinemas

AUGUST 2026	
FRI 14	Flowervale Street; PAW Patrol 3: The Dino Movie
FRI 21	Mutiny; The Bride!
FRI 28	Crime 101; Outcome
SEPTEMBER 2026 • PREVIEW	
FRI 4	Conjuring: Last Rites
FRI 11	Resident Evil reboot
FRI 18	The Black Phone 2
FRI 25	Tron: Ares (+ IMAX)
OCTOBER 2026 • PREVIEW	
FRI 16	Untitled Christopher McQuarrie thriller
FRI 23	Frankenstein (del Toro)

11 — FORWARD PLANNING • SPORT

On the sporting calendar

AUGUST 2026

SAT 15 Premier League season begins (2026/27)

22–23 Belgian Grand Prix (F1)